

Your First Day of Pickleball

A simple checklist so you know what to bring, what to expect, and what not to worry about.

WHAT TO BRING

- A paddle

A starter paddle (\$40-\$80) is plenty. Borrow one if you don't have it yet.

- Court shoes or tennis shoes

Not running shoes. Running shoes can roll your ankle sideways. Court shoes keep you stable.

- Water bottle

Pickleball is more active than it looks. Bring more water than you think you need.

- Pickleball balls (optional)

Most open play sessions have balls. Bring a few if you want to be safe.

- Comfortable athletic clothes

Shorts or a skirt with pockets. You'll hold a spare ball in them.

- Sunscreen and a hat (outdoor play)

Courts are often in full sun. You'll thank yourself later.

WHAT TO EXPECT AT OPEN PLAY

- Find the paddle line or paddle rack

Put your paddle in line when you arrive. That's how you sign up to play next.

- You'll rotate in when a court opens

Usually 4 paddles go on at once. Play one game, then rotate off and get back in line.

- Say 'I'm new' when you arrive

One sentence. Players will explain how the rotation works and be patient with you.

- Games go to 11, win by 2

It's faster than you think. You'll play several games in a session.

- Call the score before every serve

Say it loud so both teams hear it. Nobody minds if you ask what the score is.

THE 3 RULES BEGINNERS FORGET MOST

Rule	What it means
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Two-bounce rule	After the serve, the ball must bounce once on each side before anyone hits it out of the air.
The kitchen	The zone near the net. You can't volley (hit out of the air) while standing in it.
Serve underhand	Your paddle must move low to high. No overhand serves like tennis.

YOUR FIRST WEEK

- Go to open play at least twice

Once a week is too slow. Twice a week and things start clicking fast.

- Watch the kitchen line

Stand right behind it when you can. That's where points are won.

- Don't try to fix everything at once

Pick one thing to focus on each session. Serving, or dinking, or calling the score.

- Find a beginner or all-levels session

Look for those words when choosing open play times. Much friendlier.

FIND COURTS NEAR YOU

- Pickleheads (pickleheads.com)

The biggest court finder. Search by city and filter by open play times.

- Places2Play (places2play.org)

Another good directory with open play schedules.

- Facebook groups

Search your city + 'pickleball'. Local groups post games and beginner meetups.

- Parks and rec department

Many cities run free or cheap beginner sessions at public courts.
